

FIELD LIBRARY / FULL FIELD GUIDE

Power outage

UTILITIES / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

Deal first with essential medical power, unsafe heat or cold, and drinking water. Use battery light, conserve phone power and keep fridge doors closed. Assume restoration may take longer than expected. Run generators outdoors at least 20 feet from openings; never heat a home with an oven, grill or indoor generator. Relocate early if you cannot maintain essential care or safe temperature.

Do now.

**Check the situation**

01

Find the outage map and local emergency alerts. If someone depends on powered medical equipment, use the backup plan and seek urgent help if that equipment cannot run.

**Make the space safe**

02

Use flashlights rather than candles. Keep refrigerators and freezers closed. Unplug sensitive electronics if power is unstable, and leave one light on to show when service returns.

**Keep air safe**

03

A generator, camp stove, grill, or vehicle can produce deadly carbon monoxide. Keep fuel-burning equipment outside and well away from openings; use a battery-powered CO alarm if available.

**Check your people**

04

Contact neighbors who may need help. Conserve phone power, use text when calls are congested, and monitor official updates.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

Assume restoration time is uncertain. Reserve battery power for medical equipment, light and short check-ins, keep fridge doors closed and inventory safe water. If essential medical support or safe temperature cannot be maintained, move to a checked safer place early rather than waiting for an estimate.

Watch for.

Headache, dizziness, weakness, nausea, or confusion near fuel-burning equipment can signal carbon monoxide exposure. Get into fresh air and call emergency services. Never enter a flooded area to operate electrical equipment.

People & practical needs.

Choose one person to manage medical power and one to handle food, water and short contact check-ins. Keep children away from candles, electrical damage and generator fuel. Check whether a neighbor has the same immediate needs before assuming they can help.

Keep essentials within reach.

Prioritize supplies named in this guide that are usable by the person who needs them. Keep the checklist and relevant contact details accessible. Check carrying capacity, storage and equipment instructions in advance; collecting equipment must not delay the immediate protective action.

Next decisions.

If the outage continues, plan for safe temperature, water, medication refrigeration, and a place to relocate if the home becomes unsafe. Check current food-safety advice before eating perishables after a prolonged outage.

Check the next usable option

If the outage continues, plan for safe temperature, water, medication refrigeration, and a place to relocate if the home becomes unsafe. Check current food-safety advice before eating perishables after a prolonged outage.

When the first option is unavailable

Assume restoration time is uncertain. Reserve battery power for medical equipment, light and short check-ins, keep fridge doors closed and inventory safe water. If essential medical support or safe temperature cannot be maintained, move to a checked safer place early rather than waiting for an estimate.

Questions in the field.

Who depends on power?

Name the person whose medicine, mobility, temperature control or breathing support fails first. Ask their care team for a device-specific backup plan before an outage. Record battery runtime and a reachable alternative location; a power bank is not automatically compatible with medical equipment.

What if restoration keeps slipping?

Set a household reassessment time based on the shortest essential battery or temperature limit. Check the destination before moving. Do not wait for a utility estimate to become a guarantee.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

NEXT ACTION / PERSON RESPONSIBLE

Sources & limits.

Civilian educational guidance. Linked references may use U.S. emergency systems; local warning methods, laws, services and conditions differ.

Source-linked editorial guidance. Not independent clinical or specialist certification. Training and product-specific instructions remain essential.

[CDC · Protect yourself during a power outage](#)

<https://www.cdc.gov/natural-disasters/response/what-to-do-protect-yourself-during-a-power-outage.html>

[CDC · Avoid carbon monoxide poisoning](#)

<https://www.cdc.gov/natural-disasters/psa-toolkit/avoiding-carbon-monoxide-poisoning.html>

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/emergencies/power-outage/>

Content updated 2026-10-02. Saved guidance cannot provide live alerts.